

Paper C: Speaking & Listening



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Getting to know you...



Your teacher will put you into groups of 2-3. Find out as much information as you can about the other student(s) e.g.

- where they're from;
- what they've been doing recently;
- their academic field and interests;
- their short and long-term goals;
- activities they enjoy outside of study;
- anything surprising / interesting about them.

Present your partner



- Use the information you found out to present your partner to the rest of the class.
- If you were in a group of 3, you each need to present a different person.
- Your presentation should take around 1 minute and should have a clear introduction, middle and conclusion. Try to include something memorable about your partner.



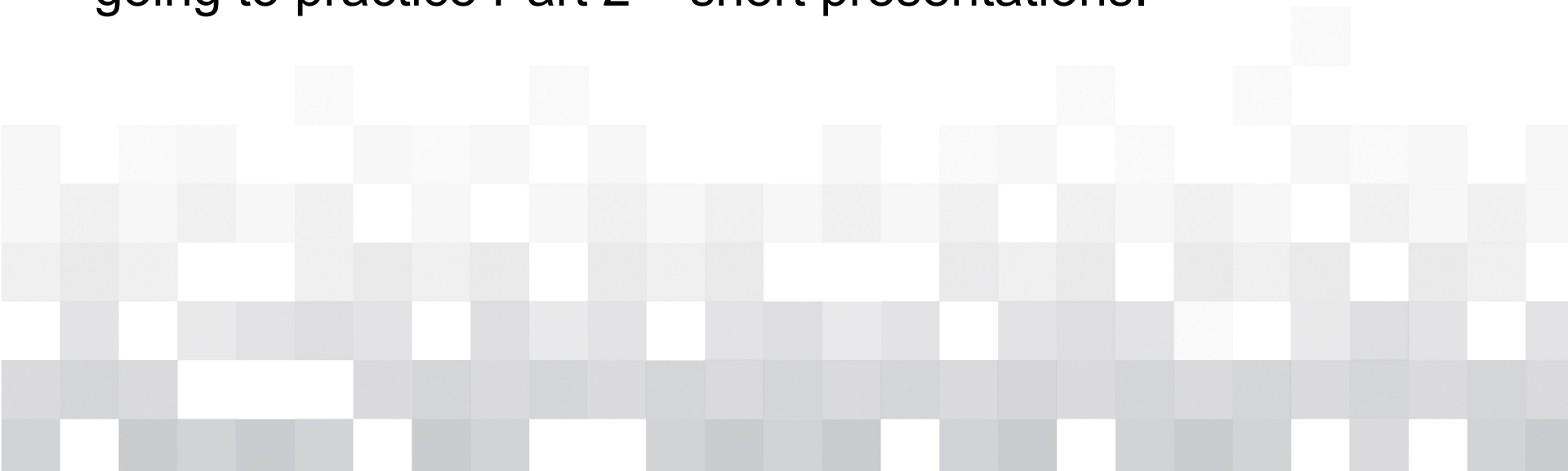
Paper C: Speaking & Listening



The speaking and listening assessment contains 3 parts:

- Part 1: general questions
- Part 2: short presentation (1-2 minutes)
- Part 3: in depth questions

You will have practice with Parts 1 & 3 later. Today we are going to practice Part 2 – short presentations.



Example



In Part 2 of the “Interview”, you will receive a prompt card. For example:

A recent survey suggests that internet users spend 147 minutes per day on social media, up from 90 minutes in 2012. To what extent do you think this is a positive development?

Discuss the question in a small group. What are your views? (Don't try to prepare a presentation at this stage)

Structuring your 2-minute presentation



There are different ways to structure a presentation including:

1. Justification
2. Synthesis
3. Rebuttal

Justification



Claim

Reason 1 plus evidence

Reason 2 plus evidence

Reason 3 plus evidence

Re-assertion of claim

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Language: claim



- In my/our opinion...
- I/We are of the opinion that...
- I/We think/believe...
- From my/our perspective/point of view...
- I/We would argue/suggest/posit that...
- I/We would like to put forward the argument...
- I/We advocate (+ noun or gerund)...
- I/We are in favour of...
- I/We are opposed to...

Language: reason plus evidence



Reason

- ...because...
- ...as...
- This is due to....

Evidence

For example...

For instance...

A clear example would be...

Evidence would include...

This is evidenced by...

This is exemplified by....

This is supported by the fact(s)
that...

Evidence to support this position
includes...

Language: re-assertion of claim



- Therefore, ...
- Thus, ...
- Consequently, ...
- As a result, ...
- Hence, ...

Justification comment



- Useful for direct persuasion, especially if supported by strong evidence
- Does not address counter-arguments



Synthesis



Position A

Position B

Synthesis



Language: Position A & Position B



- Proponents / Supporters claim / maintain / assert / contend / allege / insist suggest / point out....
- By contrast.../ In comparison.../ However.../ But...
- Opponents claim / maintain / assert / contend / allege / insist suggest / point out....

Language: Position A & Position B



- Those in favour of (the idea that)...
- Those opposed to (the idea that)...
- Defenders of (the idea that)...
- Critics of (the idea that)...
- Advocates of (the idea that)...
- Objectors to (the idea that)...

Language: synthesis



- On balance,...
- Overall,...
- Weighing up both sides of the argument...
- Having weighed the merits of both sides...



Synthesis comment



- Shows an understanding of the full debate
- If done well, evaluates the strengths & weaknesses of different sides and looks for points of agreement to form a conclusion
- Can be descriptive and may not make the writer/speaker's position clear at least at the outset

“Rebut” means to claim or prove that evidence or a claim is false.



Rebuttals



- Position you do NOT agree with
- Rebuttal (reason you do not agree)
- Your argument



Rebuttals may:



- a) Completely disagree with an argument
 - *I fundamentally/wholeheartedly/totally disagree that...*
 - *This argument completely fails to...*

- b) Accept part of an argument but disagree with other elements
 - *Although elements of this argument are persuasive, it overlooks...*
 - *There is some truth in the idea that..., but...*

- c) Reject an argument as irrelevant or outdated
 - *This argument is irrelevant/outdated because...and therefore...*

Rebuttal comment



- Good rebuttals can be quite persuasive
- However, it's important to avoid “a straw man argument” where you distort the opposing stance in order to make it easier to attack





STRAW MAN ARGUMENT

Misrepresenting
someone's position
to make it
easier to attack.

WHAT SCIENTISTS SAY

WE NEED TO
HALF CO₂ EMISSIONS
WITHIN TWELVE YEARS
TO AVOID DANGEROUS
CLIMATE CHANGE.



HOW DENIERS DISTORT

ALARMISTS
SAY THE WORLD
WILL END IN
12 YEARS!



Look at the next 3 slides which respond to this question:

A recent survey suggests that internet users spend 147 minutes per day on social media, up from 90 minutes in 2012. To what extent do you think this is a positive development?

1. Which slide is an example of:
 - a) Justification
 - b) Synthesis
 - c) Rebuttal
2. Which structure do you like best and why?
3. Highlight useful language on the slides.

Slide A:



Many people believe that spending nearly two and a half hours a day on social media is excessive, that it fuels anxiety and loneliness, and that it steals time from real-world relationships. At first glance, this concern seems reasonable.

However, I believe this pessimistic reading is misleading.

Critics assume that time online is time lost, but this ignores what people are actually doing. Much of that time is spent communicating with family, collaborating with colleagues, or running businesses. In other words, social media has absorbed activities we used to do in other ways, so the rising number reflects a shift in behaviour, not simply a decline in wellbeing.

Opponents also point to studies linking social media to poor mental health. Yet these findings usually concern a minority of heavy, passive users. For most people, moderate, active use is associated with stronger social bonds, not weaker ones.

Finally, the claim that this harms real-world relationships overlooks how online and offline life now overlap. A message to a distant friend is still a real connection.

So while the concerns are understandable, they don't hold up under scrutiny. The increase in usage reflects social media becoming a normal, useful part of modern life, and on balance I see this as a positive development.

Slide B:



In my view, the rise in social media use from 90 to 147 minutes a day is largely a positive development, and I'd like to explain why.

First, social media has transformed how we maintain relationships. People can now stay in daily contact with family and friends across continents, something that was far harder a decade ago. That extra time online often reflects deeper, more frequent connection rather than wasted hours.

Second, these platforms have become powerful tools for learning and opportunity. Millions of people use them to build small businesses, share knowledge, and access news and educational content for free. For many, the phone in their pocket is now a classroom and a marketplace at once.

Finally, social media gives ordinary people a voice. Social movements, charity campaigns, and community support networks now spread rapidly because people are spending more time in these shared spaces.

Of course, this depends on how the time is used, but the underlying trend points to greater connection, access, and participation. For these reasons, I believe the increase is, on balance, a change we should welcome rather than fear.

Slide C:



Spending time on social media is neither simply good nor bad; its value depends on how we look at it.

On one hand, there are clear benefits. Social media keeps us connected, informs us, and creates opportunities for work, learning, and community that previous generations never had. Spending more time online can mean richer relationships and wider access to information.

On the other hand, there are real costs. Nearly two and a half hours a day is significant, and research links heavy use to anxiety, poor sleep, and reduced face-to-face interaction. The platforms are also designed to be addictive, so rising numbers may reflect compulsion rather than genuine choice.

Bringing these together, I'd argue the real issue is not the quantity of time but its quality. Two hours spent learning a skill, running a business, or talking to loved ones is very different from two hours of passive, anxious scrolling.

So rather than asking whether the increase itself is positive, we should ask how that time is spent and whether we control the technology or it controls us. Seen this way, the trend is an opportunity that comes with a responsibility, and the outcome ultimately lies with us as users.

Slide A: Rebuttal



Many people believe that spending nearly two and a half hours a day on social media is excessive, that it fuels anxiety and loneliness, and that it steals time from real-world relationships. At first glance, this concern seems reasonable.

However, I believe this pessimistic reading is misleading.

Critics assume that time online is time lost, but this ignores what people are actually doing. Much of that time is spent communicating with family, collaborating with colleagues, or running businesses. In other words, social media has absorbed activities we used to do in other ways, so the rising number reflects a shift in behaviour, not simply a decline in wellbeing.

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So while the concerns are understandable, they don't hold up under scrutiny. The increase in usage reflects social media becoming a normal, useful part of modern life, and on balance I see this as a positive development.

Slide B: Justification



In my view, the rise in social media use from 90 to 147 minutes a day is largely a positive development, and I'd like to explain why.

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Slide C: Synthesis



Spending time on social media is **neither simply good nor bad**; its value depends on how we look at it.

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Individual 2-minute presentation



Your teacher will now give you an individual question to prepare a 2-minute presentation for.

Use some of the language for 'addition', 'emphasis' and 'summary' on the following slides.



Phrases for addition



- Plus...
- What's more...
- In addition...
- But there's more to it than that...
- It's also a matter of...

Phrases for emphasis



- Above all...
- In particular,...
- What's especially important is...
- I'd like to emphasize...
- The main thing is that...

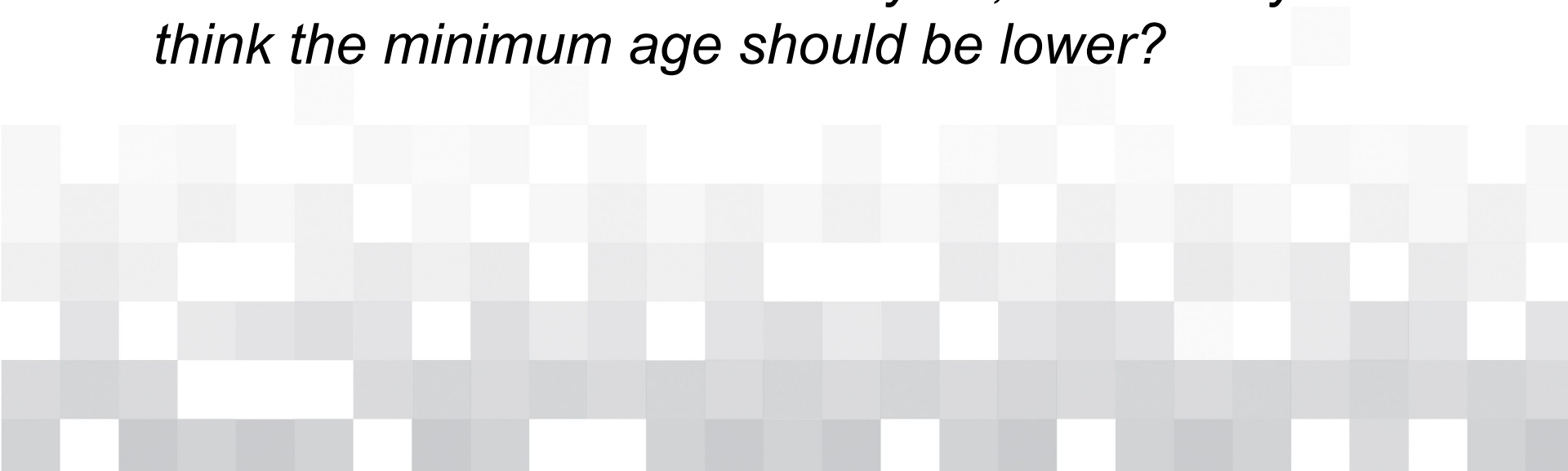


Phrases for summary



- To sum up...
- To summarize...
- Let's summarize briefly what we've looked at...
- To conclude...
- In conclusion...
- I'll conclude very briefly by saying that...

In Europe, most social media platforms have a minimum age of 16 (13 with parental consent) before a user can create an account, due to the General Data Protection Regulation, or GDPR, which came into effect on May 25, 2018. Do you think the minimum age should be lower?

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A recent mental health survey has revealed almost 8 out of 10 people believe social media has a negative impact on the mental health of young people and their families. Do you agree?



It's thought that anonymous profiles can contribute to the spread of misinformation or fake news, as well as cyberbullying, trolling and hate crime. Some are calling on social media companies to make anonymous profiles a thing of the past and require users to sign in using formal identity document. Do you think this is a good idea?

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Individual 2-minute presentation



Deliver your presentation to the rest of the group



Think about the presentations you have given and seen today:

- What went well? Think about positive examples.
- What could have been improved? Be constructive.
- What do you need to work on personally? Focus on 2-3 areas.